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### Wandering Through the Demands of Life

In my playlist, "Wandering Through the Demands of Life," I explore the arc of my challenges and hardships during the pivotal years of my teenage life. Each track delves into the demands of the changing world, the distant and near future, and the pursuit of freedom. "Wander Through the Demands of Life" discusses the issues during the pandemic and the effects it had on my school of thought and relationship with music. Listening to this playlist, you will start in the realm of the unknown and wander through times of isolation and uncertainty until finding resolve and a solution. Lyrics include words of introspection, clarity, and thoughtfulness from artists such as 2Pac, Marvin Gaye, Kanye West, and Kendrick Lamar.

Firstly, the song "What's Going On" by Marvin Gaye opens my playlist. From the classic 1971 album of the same name, Gaye uses his soulful vocals to ask listeners what is going on in the world. It is a cry for help in a tumultuous world, but also a hopeful ballad for love. Since "What's Going On" is the album opener, Gaye provides context for the project. "What's Going On" speaks to brothers, mothers, and lovers, and their struggles against police brutality, protests, and injustices that were happening in his day. This song also serves as the foremost song on this playlist, with the lyric, "Oh, you know we've got to find a way to bring some understanding here today." As an introduction, "What's Going On" sets the listener on a journey to resolve the issues of today. The formative years of being a teenager saw much change and hurt, with the

COVID-19 pandemic isolation and uproar regarding police brutality leading many to ask the same question, what's going on?

Therefore, "Changes" by 2Pac follows "What's Going On" as the second track in my playlist. Released posthumously in 1998, "Changes" is a harrowing premonition of what is happening today in the 2020s. Discussing the topics touched on by Marvin Gaye, 2Pac expands on them and adds, "There's war in the streets and war in the Middle East, instead of war on poverty, they got a war on drugs." With his more blunt perspective on the current global climate, 2Pac's approach is far grittier than Gaye's songs. 2Pac looks at our future and gives a piece of advice: "We can never go nowhere unless we share with each other, we gotta start makin' changes." This playlist keeps this piece of advice in mind as we wander through the other demands of life, a reminder to keep looking out for each other and always being curious.

Next, I chose the song "Upside Down" by Jack Johnson, recorded in 2006 for the beloved kids' movie Curious George. Finding myself in isolation, I often went back to the shows I enjoyed as an adolescent, such as The Simpsons, The Garfield Show, and Curious George. Themes of the show Curious George particularly enthralled me, a little monkey facing the big city ready to learn about everything and could do anything. At that time, I was confused and looking to read and learn about all the changes Gaye and 2Pac were discussing. Perhaps it was the words "and as my mind begins to spread its wings there's no stopping curiosity," that particularly engrossed me. Even by being inside, I could learn more about the world than I could have ever imagined, so I began searching for answers.

With this purpose, I discovered the artist Kid Cudi, and the song "Mr. Rager" from his 2010 album "Man on the Moon II: The Legend of Mr. Rager." "Mr. Rager" brings listeners into the headspace that Kid Cudi was in then, with dark and emotional lyrics that take listeners into a

state of wonder through the character “Mr. Rager.” Questions are repeatedly asked throughout the song, “Tell me where you're going, tell us where you're headed ... Mr. Rager, tell me some of your stories, tell us of your travels.” By asking these questions, “Mr. Rager” invites the listener to join him on this journey, utilizing electronic elements that feel like the song is a voyage through space. Throughout the 2020s, it felt like uncharted territory, drifting into the cosmos with no idea what would happen next. Everyone was wondering, “Can we take the journey?”

Similarly to “Mr. Rager” going on an adventure, Travis Scott’s 2018 song “ASTROTHUNDER” asks how long until we get there. “ASTROTHUNDER”’s title explains the oddities and wonder of Travis Scott’s journey with the album “Astroworld.” These lyrics, “Feels like the life I need's a little distant, yeah,” reflect how long the journey to regular life will be. Travis repeats this line over and over, drawing attention to the fact that this journey will be monotonous but wonderful. Like “Mr. Rager,” Travis uses a far more intensive use of autotune and electronic sounds to now feel deep in space, far from home. Following the start of the 2020s, it felt like a long journey with no end in sight. Time was slowly passing due to the length of isolation, days upon days without leaving the house. Though the return to normal life was distant, the odyssey to obtain it would prove to be necessary.

Succeeding the song “ASTROTHUNDER,” the song “Everyday” off of A\$AP Rocky’s 2015 album “AT.LONG.LAST.A\$AP” is the sixth track on the playlist. “Everyday” is a dive into the demands of fame and the search for balance in one’s life. Rocky’s use of the sample “In a Broken Dream” as filtered vocals from Rod Stewart and then again sung unfiltered by Miguel contrasts the monotony of every day to the grandiosity of life and emotion. A\$AP Rocky's braggadocious rapid flow stands in the face of challenge, but the song ends on an uncertain note, with the lyrics “But I don't need love no more, oh, no I'll be fine, sippin' wine Takin' time slow”

ending the song. Days were long and drawn out during isolation, with the monotony of staying inside and losing much emotion. Life was better taking time slowly.

Additionally, “B\*\*\*\*, Don’t Kill My Vibe” by Kendrick Lamar carries on this feeling of taking time slow and enjoying life. 2012 is when Kendrick Lamar’s good kid, m.A.A.d city was released, in which Kendrick discusses the struggles of growing up in Compton. “B\*\*\*\*, Don’t Kill My Vibe” created an anthem for people like Kendrick to keep steadfast in their beliefs and ward off bad vibes. With all of the hate and confusion in the world, Kendrick's words of confidence allowed many like me to push through the demands of life. For instance, Kendrick says “I can feel the changes, I can feel a new life, I always knew life can be dangerous.” Isolation allowed for the changes in the world to be broadcast worldwide, exposing the real dangers of the world. Even when leaving isolation, adaption to semi-regular life was difficult.

Due to this, I have put Frank Ocean’s 2016 song “Solo” as the eighth song of this playlist. Carrying on ideas of being alone in a new world, “Solo” discusses the mental state of isolation. Within the song, Frank Ocean speaks to his lover about himself letting him go and the ways he adapted alone. Venturing a post-pandemic world, Frank Ocean relatably discusses the difficulties of standing on one's own feet. “Solo” includes lyrics like “I’m skipping showers and switching socks, sleeping good and long” being a relatable look into what it felt for many like me to go into the world, shaking up our schedules and creating uncomfortable situations. Going into a new school we had to wear masks and social distancing was a huge undertaking to adapt to. Even with isolation over, I was still looking for ways to be free.

Accordingly, the 2018 song “Ghost Town” from the album “ye” by Kanye West follows “Solo,” with Kanye’s yearning to be free being the main idea in the song. The song utilizes a powerful guitar loop, nostalgic piano loop, and ethereal organ to craft the divine feeling of

freedom. Kanye utilizes talented singers such as a sample from Shirley Ann Lee and features from PARTYNEXTDOOR, Kid Cudi, and 070 Shake. All artists discuss their struggles with being free, Shirley Ann Lee hopes for a starry freedom, Party wants relaxation and confidence, Kid Cudi wishes to woo his estranged lover, Kanye hopes to get away from all the drama and looks for reconciliation, and finally 070 Shake wants to feel like a child again. 070 Shake's lyrics in particular, "and nothing hurts anymore, I feel kinda free We're still the kids we used to be," relate to the feeling of being still a kid in the post-pandemic world and the realization that freedom is what you make it. Freedom will be the changes that you make in yourself, not the ones that happen around you.

Finally, the 1987 Michael Jackson classic "Man in the Mirror" from the album "Bad" rounds out my playlist. "Man in the Mirror" is a plea to the world to make changes in themselves to change the world. MJ's cry, "If they wanna make the world a better place Take a look at yourself and then make a change" brings the playlist full circle. When 2Pac and Marvin Gaye discussed the changes in the world, MJ gave them a solution, allowing everyone to reflect on themselves and create something great. This song resolves the journey described in "Mr. Rager" and "ASTROTHUNDER" by deciding that the journey is more important than the destination. "B\*\*\*\*, Don't Kill My Vibe" and "Solo" are reconciled, with MJ insisting that even through one's struggle, they could find a brother experiencing the same issues. Throughout the song, MJ tells the listeners to "stand up, and lift yourself," urging them to lift themselves to the freedoms Kanye discussed in "Ghost Town." As the final song, it provides the perfect resolution and thing for listeners to think about after listening to the playlist.

In conclusion, this playlist has summarized my reactions to the pivotal years of my life, with songs discussing social change, adventure, and freedom. It started during the confusing time

of the pandemic, then the drawn-out times of isolation and uncertainty of the future, and resolved when returning to the post-pandemic world to make my changes. Music and its role in my life has changed from something I experienced in the sensuous plane, to something I view as expressive and meaningful. During the covid pandemic, it was a time when I stopped listening to the radio and was able to digest all the lyrics without distraction. Pandemic isolation has brought everyone into new mind spaces, creating new schools of thinking for everyone. The most important thing we can hold on to as a civilization is our stories, art, and thoughts, without them humanity would just be another blip in the vast length of the universe.

My Playlist Link:

<https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3YKQpq01EVwsyJmO8h6Nts?si=Gd35jBx5RpGFQHkvYYHnjQ&pi=u-gXlK5yPXTxWr>